

Bain Capital, 11North Partners Pay \$300M for Five Open-Air Malls

\$300 million

Key figure

On Wednesday, Bain Capital and 11North Partners closed a \$300 million acquisition of five open-air malls across four states. The portfolio spans 757,000 square feet.

The numbers tell the story

\$300 million

Key figure

\$185 billion

Key figure

\$396

Debt / financing

What happened

On Wednesday, Bain Capital and 11North Partners closed a \$300 million acquisition of five open-air malls across four states. The portfolio spans 757,000 square feet. Properties include the Beacon in Carlsbad, Calif.; Barcroft Plaza in Falls Church, Va.; West Town Corners in Altamonte Springs, Fla.; and University Commons in Sugar Land, Texas. University Commons was sold by Vista Private Equity Group.

The money

Bain Capital is a multi-asset alternative investment firm with \$185 billion in assets under management. 11North Partners is a New York-based real estate investment firm focused on retail. The two formed an exclusive joint venture for this transaction.

The market reaction

Retail has surged over the last year as demand rises and capital markets stabilize, according to Cushman & Wakefield research. Open-air malls lead the recovery. Foot traffic at these centers increased 6.4 percent between January and February of this year, per Placer.ai data. That metric is the strongest in the retail sector.

The money

Brian Harper, founder and managing partner at 11North, described open-air, grocery-anchored retail as demonstrating some of the most compelling risk-adjusted fundamentals in real estate. He said the firm is acquiring high-quality, irreplaceable assets in undersupplied markets at a basis structurally difficult to replicate.

The money

The deal is private. No financing details were released. Bain Capital and 11North Partners did not disclose leverage levels, debt sources, or cap rates. Institutional buyers in this segment typically target stabilized yields between 6.5 percent and 8.0 percent on grocery-anchored centers, per CBRE data. At \$300 million, the portfolio likely generates \$19.5 million to \$24 million in annual net operating income.

The story

Open-air malls have outperformed enclosed malls for five consecutive quarters, according to Cushman & Wakefield. The shift accelerated during the pandemic as consumers favored drive-to, outdoor formats. Grocery-anchored centers benefit from non-discretionary spending patterns. Vacancy rates for grocery-anchored retail hover near 4.5 percent nationally, per CoStar data.

The market reaction

Bain Capital's entry is notable. The firm has been selective in retail, focusing on necessity-based assets with strong demographic tailwinds. Its proprietary data-driven underwriting framework evaluates markets, submarkets, and individual assets. Kelley said this framework allows precision and conviction that is differentiated in the sector.

The money

11North Partners brings operating expertise. The firm has acquired over \$1.5 billion in retail assets since inception. Its strategy targets value-add opportunities in open-air centers, often repositioning through tenant mix optimization and capital improvements. The joint venture structure allows Bain to leverage 11North's execution capabilities while maintaining institutional governance.

The transaction

The acquisition signals a broader shift. Institutional capital that fled retail during the pandemic is returning, but selectively. Grocery-anchored, open-air centers are the preferred vehicle. The thesis rests on three pillars: necessity-based demand, limited new supply, and rising barriers to entry in infill locations. Each of the five properties sits in a metro area with population growth above the national average.

The final read

What this deal does not say is as important as what it does. It does not signal a broad retail recovery. It signals a bifurcation. Class A open-air centers with strong anchors and dense trade areas attract institutional capital. Class B and C malls, especially enclosed, remain distressed. The gap between winners and losers is widening.

If foot traffic continues to rise, more capital will follow.

The headline is the transaction. The story is the structure.

If the capital stack works, the deal becomes a signal. If it does not, it becomes a warning.

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